

Ludic Musicking – Dungeon Delving Rules

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1 Dungeon Delving Rules

Playing material, including Rooms booklet, decans tiles and grid, is available in PDF format at this [link](#).

1.1 Setup

To experience this essay you will need ¹:

- Pen and paper, to record information of your journey, such as hints gathered through the **Scout** action.
- Three six-sided dice (2D6), preferably of different colors. Two of them will be used for **The Wheel** mechanism, while the last one will serve during the **Scout** action.
- A 6 x 6 grid, either drawn or printed. Rows are labelled with letters from A to F, while digits from 1 to 6 are assigned to columns.
- 36 decans tiles, available as printable PDF or individual SVG files.
- 10 wall markers of grid length 2.
- A set of tokens to represent the party's **Karma**, **Visit**, **Secret Key**, and **Action Points**.
- One pawn, representing your adventuring party's position in the dungeon.
- A printed or digital version of the **Rooms** content, Player's Turn and Wheel Random Table.

Before starting to play:

- Assign yourself **Karma** tokens. The lesser tokens, the harder the game will be. We advice for a number between 2 (hard) and 4 (easy).
- Place randomly five wall markers for each row, and as much of them for the columns.
- Randomly distribute the 36 decans tiles on the grid face down.

1. All printing material will be available in PDF print-friendly format at the following URL: https://github.com/NicholasCorniaOrpheus/whirlpool-of-imaginary-sounds/raw/refs/heads/main/articles/iwp_2026/ludic_musicking_printing_material.zip.

1.2 Player Turn

1. Spend 4 action points in order to perform a combination of **Advance** and **Scout** actions.
2. Read the **Room** content of the tile where your pawn has landed.
3. Place a **Visit** token on the tile. If the number of piled tokens reaches three, the **Dragon** awakens and the game is over.
4. The **Wheel** activates, moving the walls based on the result of the previous turn. Ignore this step on the first turn.
5. Roll to determine the following move of **The Wheel** according to the 2D6 Random Table.

1.3 End-of-game

The game ends in one of the following circumstances:

- The adventurers have collected 3 **Artefact Fragments**. You win.
- If the player visits the same cell three times, the guarding **Dragon** awakes and feasts on the flesh of the adventurers. Game over.
- If **Karma** reaches 0 game is over.

1.4 Actions

At the beginning of each turn, the player receives 4 **Action Points** to be spend for any combination of the **Advance** and **Scout** actions.

1.4.1 Advance

The player moves the pawn representing the adventuring party to an adjacent tile. A tile is adjacent if the distance between the source and destination is one and there are no walls impeding the passage. Diagonal moves are not allowed.

1.4.2 Scout

Roll a D6. If the result is higher than your current **Karma** value you can reveal the content of an adjacent **Room**. Note that you may use a **Secret Key** in combination with this action in order to gain information of a tile behind a wall.

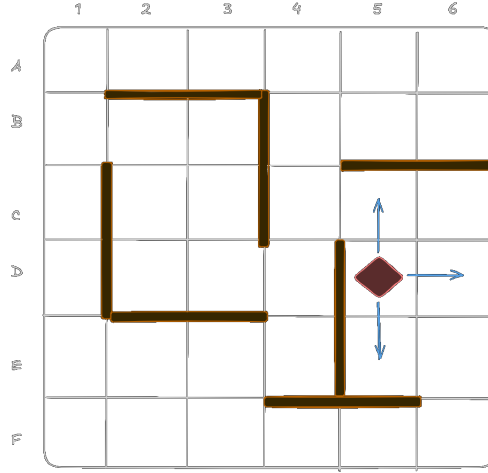


Figure 1: Example of the Advance action on the grid. The arrows indicate the adjacent cells.

1.5 The Wheel

Combinatorial wheels, *volvelles*, *gorghi d'artificio* of Early Modernity have been considered precursors of modern computers, paper machines capable of storing, processing and creating knowledge through ingenious mechanical devices and complex symbolic mappings². In order to praise their elegance as *devices of wonder* (Stafford 2002) I have introduced an additional element to the dungeon delving experience: **The Wheel**. The dungeon is an inimical place, and it has a power of its own in order to banish and crush unwelcome visitors by rearranging its spaciality in order to confuse, constrain and obliterate (Roast 2023).

In order to simulate this constant menace, at the end of each player's turn, two six-sided dice (2D6) are rolled in order to determine the behavior of **The Wheel** mechanism for the next adventuring turn. The first result refers to which row a wall is going to move, while the second indicates on which column a wall will be activated.

2. For an extensive discussion on combinatorial wheels as mnemonic and combinatorial tools see (Bolzoni 2005), (Bolzoni 2012) and (Eco 2017). Anthologies dedicated to these ingenious devices are (Kupfer, Cohen, and Chajes 2020) and (Crupi 2024).

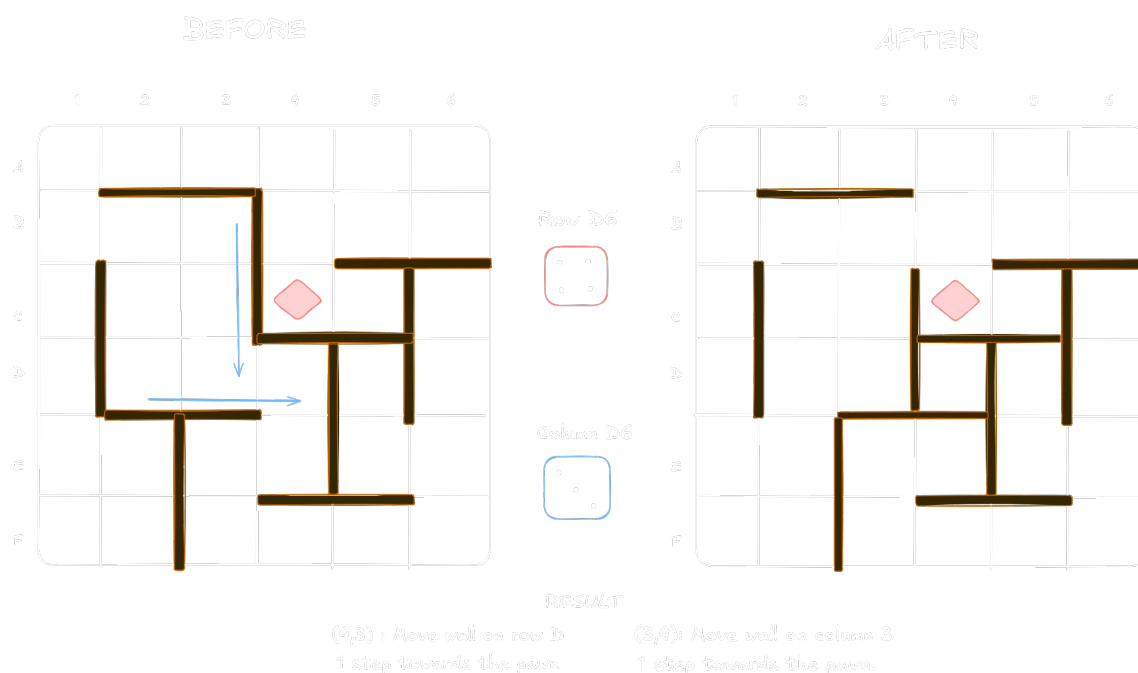


Figure 2: Example of the Wheel. The combined result of the two dice is interpreted according to the aforementioned table.

Wheel 2d6 Random Table ³

d6	column	row	movement
1	1	A	one step away from the pawn
2	2	B	one step away the pawn
3	3	C	one step towards the pawn
4	4	D	one step towards from the pawn
5	5	E	one step towards the pawn
6	None	None	player chooses the direction

Note that the current position of the pawn (when the dice of **The Wheel** mechanism are rolled) determine if a wall moves away or towards it. The following figure provides a practical example of the procedure.

1.6 Effects

Dungeon rooms are not just filled with primordial astrological symbols and witty citations about playful thinking. Wandering monsters, hazards and wondrous items can be found within these inhospitable chambers.

3. We have changed the movement corresponding to the die result with respect to the playthrough recording of May 2026. Moving away from the pawn is now related to die results of 1 and 2, while moving towards the pawn is related to 3-5 results. Note that this asymmetry is deliberate: don't forget that the dungeon is trying to confine the adventurers!

After reading the **Room**, resolve the **Effect** associated with the current location of your adventuring party on the grid.

1.6.1 Wandering Monster

A foul creature is facing the party. Loose one **Karma**.

1.6.2 Hazard

A pit trap or similar device used to hinder treasure robbers. Loose one **Karma** or let **The Wheel** activate without notice. After resolving point 4 of the Player's Turn (by activating **The Wheel** according to the previous dice roll), roll again 2D6 and resolve immediately the result according to the Random Table.

1.6.3 Secret Key

For the current turn the pawn can get through an adjacent wall, making the tiles behind it adjacent. Remove the token once you have used it.

1.6.4 Treasure

Gain one **Karma** or an extra **Action Point** to be used during the next turn. Note that you can keep up to five **Karma**.

1.6.5 Artefact Fragment

The adventurers have retrieved one piece of the precious artefact they are seeking.

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